The rationale for taxing sugar-sweetened beverages.

As one of the most significant public health problems in twenty-first century, obesity and diet-related diseases have attracted widespread attention. In this regard, among various factors, the excessive intake of sugar-sweetened beverages should be given great importance, as these drinks contain a large amount of free sugar and do not cause satiety. This essay contends that governments should levy a tax on sugar-sweetened beverages. As a result, consumption is reduced, the proceeds can support public health programs, and enterprises will change their behaviours to develop healthier products.

For starters, we know empirically that taxes have an effect in reducing sugary drinks consumption. After the implementation of a tax of one penny per ounce in Mexico, the purchases of taxed drinks dropped an average of 7.6 percent during 2 years (highest drop in poorer households), (Colchero et al., 2016). Or another example, a study about potential pricing strategies in the UK suggests that a twenty percent tax would decrease the obesity prevalence by roughly 1.3 percent in adults. With this strategy, they would avoid about 180,000 cases (Mytton et al., 2012). Therefore, price signals are capable of effectively guiding people to avoid consumption of harmful products.

Secondly, tax revenue provides a dedicated source of funding for health promotion activities. For example, in Berkeley, California, the first US city to implement a soda tax, the funds are being used for school nutrition programmes and community health projects. This is further enhancing the overall impact of the policy (Falbe et al., 2016). By earmarking the revenue from the tax, it can be targeted towards the communities with the highest rates of sugary drink consumption and so the communities where diet-related disease is prevalent. This means that the health promotion and equity aims can be addressed simultaneously.

Sugar taxes are often condemned as regressive and paternalistic, placing a disproportionate financial burden on the least well off consumers. While this argument has some validity, it fails to recognise two important points: the health burden of sugary drinks is in itself regressive, disproportionately affecting the poor; and the potential for progressive spending of tax income to offset the extra spending. Furthermore, the evidence from the industry response to taxation indicates that the effects are not purely about paternalism-more than half of products were reformulations to reduce sugar content in response to the UK tax, delivering the benefit to all consumers whether or not they altered their purchasing behaviour (Bandy et al., 2020).

Conclusion To sum up, sugar-sweetened beverage taxation is an evidence-based proportional measure to address a major public health issue. It reduces consumption in situations where voluntary interventions have not succeeded. It finances complementary health programmes. It encourages reformulation in the interest of health. It's time for

governments that have been reluctant to act to realise that the question is not anymore 'Does sugar-sweetened beverage taxation work?' but 'How to do it in a fair way?'

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